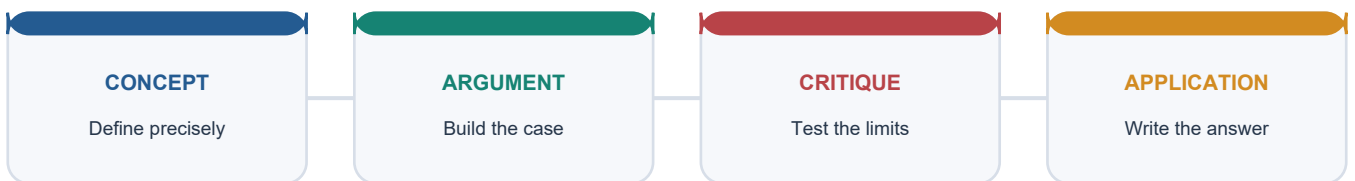


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sources of Ancient Indian History - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Sources of Ancient Indian History - Solved Practice Workbook

Exact standard. The 32 questions below are original, hard, source-method MCQs. Correct options rotate strictly **A** -> **B** -> **C** -> **D** eight times. Every item contains four substantive option-specific explanations and a unique question-specific trap.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQs

Q1

Which statement best distinguishes provenance from archaeological provenience?

- **A.** Provenance records ownership and recovery history, while provenience records the precise three-dimensional find context.
- **B.** Provenance dates an object absolutely, while provenience dates it relatively.
- **C.** Provenance applies only to texts, while provenience applies only to coins.
- **D.** The terms are interchangeable in all historical writing.

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: provenance concerns documented origin and custody; provenience is the exact archaeological location and association.
- **B:** Incorrect: neither term by itself supplies an absolute or relative date.
- **C:** Incorrect: both concepts can matter for many material source classes.
- **D:** Incorrect: archaeology uses the distinction because find context and ownership history answer different questions.

Trap 1 - Near-synonym trap: the terms look interchangeable, but the spatial archaeological meaning is narrower.

Q2

A historian is studying household food practices in a Chalcolithic settlement. Which source strategy is most appropriate?

- **A.** Begin with royal inscriptions because contemporaneity creates a universal hierarchy of reliability.
- **B.** Prioritise plant, animal, residue and context data, then use texts only where chronology and scale match.
- **C.** Use later normative texts alone because they preserve the most elaborate classifications.
- **D.** Treat any single diagnostic pot as a complete representation of household diet.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: a royal record is poorly fitted to routine household food practice.
- **B:** Correct: archaeobotany, faunal remains and residue evidence directly address diet when contextualised.
- **C:** Incorrect: later prescriptions cannot substitute for contemporaneous household evidence.
- **D:** Incorrect: one artefact cannot represent a complete food system without assemblage and context.

Trap 2 - Fixed-hierarchy trap: source value depends on the question, not prestige or contemporaneity alone.

Q3

Consider the following statements: 1. An assemblage includes associated artefacts, ecofacts and structures. 2. An archaeological culture automatically identifies one language community. 3. A single artefact outside context can securely define a settlement's chronology. Which is correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: statement 2 turns a material pattern into a linguistic identity without independent evidence.
- B: Incorrect: both statements 2 and 3 overstate what material classification can prove.
- C: Correct: only statement 1 accurately defines an assemblage.
- D: Incorrect: statements 2 and 3 ignore identity and context limits.

Trap 3 - Identity-conversion trap: recurring objects do not mechanically equal a people, language or polity.

Q4

Which excavation design is correctly matched with its principal strength?

- A. Horizontal exposure-long occupational sequence through a narrow trench
- B. Vertical trench-complete plan of one settlement phase
- C. Remote sensing-exact date and function without ground verification
- D. Vertical trench-sequence; horizontal exposure-layout of a selected phase

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: that description belongs primarily to vertical excavation.
- B: Incorrect: a narrow vertical trench usually reveals limited horizontal plan.
- C: Incorrect: remote sensing identifies anomalies and targets, not exact chronology or function.
- D: Correct: the two strategies answer complementary chronological and spatial questions.

Trap 4 - Method-swap trap: UPSC often exchanges the defining purpose of vertical and horizontal excavation.

Q5

With reference to radiocarbon dating, which statement is most accurate?

- A. It estimates a calibrated probability range for the death of organic material, subject to contamination and association.
- B. It directly dates stone tools by measuring their carbon content.
- C. It produces the exact calendar year of the historical event linked to a sample.
- D. Its result automatically dates every structure in the excavated layer.

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Correct: C-14 dates suitable organic material and retains uncertainty and context conditions.
- B: Incorrect: stone is not directly dated by ordinary radiocarbon measurement.

- **C:** Incorrect: calibrated outputs are probability ranges, not exact event years.
- **D:** Incorrect: the sample-event relationship must be demonstrated.

Trap 5 - False-precision trap: a laboratory number is not an exact civilisation-wide date.

Q6

Which one of the following is correctly paired?

- **A.** Thermoluminescence-time since organic death
- **B.** Optically stimulated luminescence-time since mineral grains were last sufficiently exposed to light
- **C.** Radiocarbon-time since pottery was last fired
- **D.** Palaeography-absolute chemical date of an inscription

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: organic death is the target of radiocarbon dating.
- **B:** Correct: OSL estimates the time since suitable grains were last adequately exposed to light.
- **C:** Incorrect: last firing is addressed by luminescence methods, not ordinary radiocarbon dating.
- **D:** Incorrect: palaeography provides approximate script-based relative dating.

Trap 6 - Target-material trap: methods are distinguished by what physical event and material they measure.

Q7

Which inference is safest when archaeobotanical and faunal remains occur in a secure context?

- **A.** They identify the language spoken by the settlement.
- **B.** They establish a single uniform diet for the whole region.
- **C.** They can illuminate crops, fuel, diet and animal use, subject to recovery and sampling bias.
- **D.** They eliminate the need for stratigraphic analysis.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: biological remains do not encode spoken language.
- **B:** Incorrect: one sampled context cannot establish regional uniformity.
- **C:** Correct: these remains expand subsistence history while remaining preservation- and sample-bound.
- **D:** Incorrect: context and stratigraphy remain necessary for interpretation.

Trap 7 - Scale-jump trap: a household or trench sample cannot be inflated into a regional social rule.

Q8

Which statement about ancient DNA and isotope evidence is correct?

- **A.** Ancient DNA directly identifies caste because caste is biologically fixed.
- **B.** Stable isotopes reveal political allegiance from skeletal material.
- **C.** A cemetery sample automatically represents the entire civilisation.
- **D.** These methods can address ancestry, relatedness, diet or mobility, but not directly language, caste, religion or polity.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: caste is a historical-social category and cannot be read directly from DNA.
- **B:** Incorrect: isotopes address environmental exposure, diet or mobility, not allegiance.
- **C:** Incorrect: burial and preservation create severe sampling limits.
- **D:** Correct: the methods answer bounded biological and environmental questions.

Trap 8 - Biological-determinism trap: laboratory evidence cannot directly name social and cultural identities.

Q9

Which statement concerning Ashokan inscriptions is correct?

- **A.** Most use Prakrit in Brahmi, while north-western contexts also include Kharoshthi and Greek-Aramaic settings.
- **B.** All are Sanskrit texts written only in Brahmi.
- **C.** Kharoshthi was normally written left to right across peninsular India.
- **D.** Script and language are always identical categories.

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: the corpus varies by region, script and linguistic setting.
- **B:** Incorrect: Sanskrit is not the language of the majority of Ashokan edicts.
- **C:** Incorrect: Kharoshthi is right to left and associated especially with the north-west.
- **D:** Incorrect: one script can write different languages and one language can use different scripts.

Trap 9 - Script-language fusion trap: medium and language must be tested independently.

Q10

The safest statement about James Prinsep and decipherment is that

- **A.** he deciphered the Harappan script completely in 1837.
- **B.** his decisive 1837 Brahmi step emerged from cumulative comparison, while Kharoshthi work also drew on bilingual coins.
- **C.** he proved that every Brahmi inscription belonged to Ashoka.
- **D.** decipherment by itself establishes the date, authenticity and social meaning of every inscription.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: the Harappan script remains undeciphered.
- **B:** Correct: decipherment was cumulative and depended on comparative epigraphic-numismatic evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: Brahmi continued beyond Ashoka and records many issuers and languages.
- **D:** Incorrect: reading signs does not finish source criticism.

Trap 10 - Heroic-genius trap: decipherment is cumulative scholarship, not an isolated flash that solves every context.

Q11

Which pairing of inscriptional genre and evidentiary caution is correct?

- **A.** Edict-its announcement proves complete implementation.
- **B.** Land grant-the legal text proves identical enforcement everywhere.
- **C.** Prashasti-valuable for genealogy and political language, but shaped by eulogy and omission.
- **D.** Donative inscription-represents every social group equally.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: declared policy and implementation are separate questions.
- **B:** Incorrect: a legal act does not demonstrate uniform practice.
- **C:** Correct: praise texts contain historical data but require rhetorical criticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: donor records widen evidence yet retain selection and survival bias.

Trap 11 - Genre-transparency trap: inscriptional contemporaneity does not erase purpose and formula.

Q12

An undated inscription is most responsibly assigned an approximate date by

- **A.** using its present museum shelf number.
- **B.** accepting the dynasty praised in a modern catalogue without verification.
- **C.** matching only the shape of one letter to a pan-Indian fixed sequence.
- **D.** combining regional palaeography, language, formula, ruler, archaeological context and comparable dated records.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: modern cataloguing does not date ancient production.
- **B:** Incorrect: catalogue attributions require independent checking.
- **C:** Incorrect: script development varies regionally and cannot rest on one letter.
- **D:** Correct: converging relative indicators produce the safest palaeographic range.

Trap 12 - Single-indicator trap: palaeographic dating is comparative and regional, not a one-letter calendar.

Q13

Which set of observations is most complete for reading a coin historically?

- **A.** Metal, weight, manufacture, legend, image, die relation, wear and find context
- **B.** Portrait and modern auction price only
- **C.** Religious symbol without legend or metrology
- **D.** Present collection location and visual beauty

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: numismatics integrates physical, textual, visual and contextual attributes.
- **B:** Incorrect: market price and portrait omit issue and archaeological evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: isolated iconography invites over-interpretation.
- **D:** Incorrect: museum or collection location may be unrelated to ancient circulation.

Trap 13 - Portrait-first trap: a coin is an object and exchange instrument, not merely a miniature royal image.

Q14

In a securely documented coin hoard, the latest coin generally provides

- **A.** the exact day on which the hoard was buried.
- **B.** a terminus after which burial occurred, subject to circulation and deposit history.

- C. proof that every coin type circulated equally in the region.
- D. the exact political frontier of the issuing ruler.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: the day of burial is rarely recoverable from the latest issue alone.
- B: Correct: the latest issue sets an earliest possible burial boundary, not an exact date.
- C: Incorrect: a hoard is a selected accumulation.
- D: Incorrect: coins can travel beyond political control.

Trap 14 - Latest-coin trap: terminus post quem is an inequality, not an exact burial timestamp.

Q15

A concentration of coins issued by one polity outside its presumed core territory most safely indicates

- A. automatic annexation of the find region.
- B. that political borders never existed.
- C. movement through trade, payment, saving or long circulation, with sovereignty requiring other evidence.
- D. that the coins are modern forgeries.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: circulation can exceed territorial control.
- B: Incorrect: coin movement does not abolish political boundaries.
- C: Correct: distribution maps movement first; sovereignty is a separate claim.
- D: Incorrect: an external findspot is not by itself evidence of forgery.

Trap 15 - Empire-map trap: coin distribution is not coextensive with political territory.

Q16

A reduction in the precious-metal content of a coin series can be explained only after testing

- A. whether the ruler changed religion.
- B. whether later literature calls the reign immoral.
- C. whether the coins display fewer deities.
- D. metal supply, monetary demand, fiscal policy, denomination and wear rather than assuming economic collapse.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: religious change does not explain alloy composition by itself.
- B: Incorrect: moral literary judgement is not metallurgical evidence.
- C: Incorrect: iconographic count is unrelated to metal purity.
- D: Correct: debasement is multi-causal and requires economic and technical context.

Trap 16 - Collapse-default trap: compositional change is evidence to explain, not a one-word crisis diagnosis.

Q17

Which chronological distinction is essential when using an ancient literary work?

- **A.** Composition, redaction, recension, surviving copy and narrated event may belong to different dates.
- **B.** The manuscript copy date automatically dates every passage.
- **C.** Oral transmission prevents any historical use.
- **D.** A modern translation eliminates interpolation.

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: textual chronology contains several distinct historical moments.
- **B:** Incorrect: a late copy can transmit much older and later layers.
- **C:** Incorrect: oral transmission creates methodological questions, not total uselessness.
- **D:** Incorrect: translation cannot remove textual layering.

Trap 17 - One-date trap: texts possess transmission histories rather than a single universal date.

Q18

Dharmashastra is most responsibly used as evidence for

- **A.** uniform conduct across all regions and groups.
- **B.** normative ideals, legal-social categories and anxieties, checked against practice-oriented evidence.
- **C.** the exact population ratio of varnas.
- **D.** the daily behaviour of every household.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: prescription is not uniform practice.
- **B:** Correct: the genre reveals norms and categories whose implementation must be tested.
- **C:** Incorrect: such texts are not demographic censuses.
- **D:** Incorrect: household behaviour requires different evidence.

Trap 18 - Norm-practice trap: repeated injunctions can reveal anxiety precisely because compliance was not automatic.

Q19

Which statement best compares Buddhist, Jaina and Sangam texts?

- **A.** All are contemporaneous chronicles with fixed authorship.
- **B.** Their non-Brahmanical position makes them free from sectarian or literary purpose.
- **C.** They diversify evidence on institutions, merchants and regions, but require chronology, genre and redaction criticism.
- **D.** Only Sangam literature can be correlated with archaeology.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: these corpora are layered and genre-diverse.
- **B:** Incorrect: alternative viewpoint does not remove didactic or sectarian framing.
- **C:** Correct: their distinctive perspectives are valuable within source limits.
- **D:** Incorrect: all textual corpora can be compared with suitable independent evidence.

Trap 19 - Alternative-equals-neutral trap: a different standpoint remains a standpoint.

Q20

A critical edition of an epic primarily

- A. selects the newest manuscript as automatically authentic.
- B. removes all regional variation from history.
- C. proves the historical occurrence of every narrated event.
- D. compares manuscript witnesses, proposes a reasoned text and records variants in an apparatus.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: manuscript age alone does not settle textual priority.
- B: Incorrect: variation is documented rather than erased from historical analysis.
- C: Incorrect: textual editing does not verify narrated events.
- D: Correct: comparison and explicit variants are the central scholarly functions.

Trap 20 - Original-restoration trap: a critical edition is an argued reconstruction, not a time machine.

Q21

Which checklist best controls the use of a foreign traveller?

- A. Route, duration, purpose, language, informants, audience, direct observation, hearsay and transmission
- B. Nationality alone
- C. Whether the account praises India
- D. Whether the traveller was chronologically close to one ruler

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Correct: observer position and transmission determine evidentiary reach.
- B: Incorrect: nationality does not describe itinerary or access.
- C: Incorrect: praise or criticism alone does not rank reliability.
- D: Incorrect: proximity to a ruler does not create an all-India social survey.

Trap 21 - Outsider-objectivity trap: distance changes the angle; it does not cancel selection and bias.

Q22

Why must Megasthenes be used with special transmission caution?

- A. He wrote only in Brahmi.
- B. His original work is lost and survives substantially through quotations or summaries by later classical authors.
- C. He never visited the Mauryan world.
- D. His account is a copper-plate grant.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- A: Incorrect: Megasthenes wrote in a classical Greek context, not Brahmi.
- B: Correct: later transmission can select, compress or reshape the lost original.
- C: Incorrect: his value is linked to Mauryan observation, though its scope is debated.
- D: Incorrect: the source is literary testimony, not an Indian epigraph.

Trap 22 - Survival-channel trap: a source may be early while its accessible wording is mediated by later authors.

Q23

An image of a deity on a coin most securely demonstrates

- **A.** the private exclusive faith of every coin user.
- **B.** the absence of political purpose in religious imagery.
- **C.** an official representational choice that may serve cult, legitimacy or convention, requiring contextual interpretation.
- **D.** the exact theological beliefs of the entire population.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: issuer imagery cannot reveal every user's faith.
- **B:** Incorrect: religious iconography can be deeply political.
- **C:** Correct: iconography records representation, not transparent inner belief.
- **D:** Incorrect: population-wide theology cannot be inferred from one official medium.

Trap 23 - Image-as-belief trap: representation is evidence of messaging before it is evidence of private faith.

Q24

Which statement about seals, pottery, manuscripts and oral traditions is correct?

- **A.** A pottery type is automatically an ethnic group.
- **B.** An undeciphered seal can yield a complete political narrative.
- **C.** A manuscript's copy date is always its composition date.
- **D.** Each can yield historical evidence, but context, decipherment, transmission and performance limits differ.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: ceramic classification is not ethnic identification.
- **B:** Incorrect: undeciphered signs constrain textual claims.
- **C:** Incorrect: copying and composition are separate dates.
- **D:** Correct: the source classes require different criticism rather than one rule of transparency.

Trap 24 - Mixed-source trap: each medium has its own failure mode even when all are material objects.

Q25

The distinction between indigenous and foreign evidence is best handled by

- **A.** rejecting any fixed reliability hierarchy and evaluating each source's access, purpose, genre and corroboration.
- **B.** assuming indigenous texts know all regions equally.
- **C.** assuming foreign accounts are neutral because they are external.
- **D.** using only the source written closest to the event.

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: standpoint matters, but reliability is question-specific.

- **B:** Incorrect: indigenous authors also have regional and social limits.
- **C:** Incorrect: foreign observers have route and translation filters.
- **D:** Incorrect: proximity alone does not remove bias or genre.

Trap 25 - Inside-outside trap: location of the observer is one variable, not a hierarchy of truth.

Q26

Two later chronicles reproduce the same earlier genealogy, while an inscription and coin series independently support part of it. Which is the strongest reasoning?

- **A.** Count the two chronicles as two independent confirmations.
- **B.** Treat the chronicles as one transmission pathway and give added weight to independent epigraphic-numismatic convergence.
- **C.** Reject the genealogy because one part remains unconfirmed.
- **D.** Accept the entire genealogy because any convergence proves the whole.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: copying or common dependence defeats independence.
- **B:** Correct: triangulation tests independent origin and supports only the convergent part.
- **C:** Incorrect: partial confirmation can still improve a bounded claim.
- **D:** Incorrect: evidence for one segment does not validate the whole sequence.

Trap 26 - Witness-count trap: multiple texts can be one evidentiary lineage.

Q27

Absence of coin finds becomes relatively stronger negative evidence when

- **A.** coins are aesthetically expected.
- **B.** a literary text does not mention a mint.
- **C.** coin-using contexts were likely to preserve finds, have been intensively sampled, and show a patterned silence.
- **D.** one unexcavated site has yielded no hoard.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: aesthetic expectation has no evidentiary force.
- **B:** Incorrect: textual silence about a mint does not settle material circulation.
- **C:** Correct: survivability, search coverage and pattern are conditions for negative inference.
- **D:** Incorrect: an unexcavated site's silence is weak.

Trap 27 - Absence-equals-nonexistence trap: negative evidence requires an expectation model and adequate search.

Q28

A spectacular antiquity appears on the market without documented recovery history. The safest historical response is to

- **A.** assign it to a famous dynasty from style alone.
- **B.** treat auction provenance as archaeological provenience.
- **C.** use it to rewrite regional chronology immediately.

- **D.** test authenticity and custody, retain only bounded material/style observations, and avoid contextual claims lost with provenience.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: style alone can be circular and forgery-prone.
- **B:** Incorrect: ownership history cannot recreate find context.
- **C:** Incorrect: an uncontextualised object is too weak for chronological revision.
- **D:** Correct: provenance ethics and forgery control protect historical inference.

Trap 28 - Masterpiece trap: visual quality does not restore destroyed archaeological relationships.

Q29

Which source combination is best suited to reconstruct gendered agency?

- **A.** Prescriptive texts read with female donative inscriptions, household archaeology and iconography, each with selection limits
- **B.** Dharmashastra alone
- **C.** Royal panegyrics alone
- **D.** Coin portraits alone

Correct answer: A.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Correct: norms, recorded acts, material practice and representation answer different dimensions.
- **B:** Incorrect: prescription reveals ideals but not the full range of practice.
- **C:** Incorrect: panegyrics are an elite political genre.
- **D:** Incorrect: portraits provide narrow official representation.

Trap 29 - Single-archive gender trap: marginalised lives often appear only through cross-reading unequal archives.

Q30

What is the most accurate statement about museums, archives, the ASI and digital databases?

- **A.** Institutional custody makes every catalogue attribution final.
- **B.** They preserve, document and widen access, but metadata, collection history, transcription and provenance still require criticism.
- **C.** Digitisation authenticates and dates manuscripts automatically.
- **D.** A database hit is equivalent to inspecting the object or authoritative edition.

Correct answer: B.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: catalogues can be revised with better evidence.
- **B:** Correct: institutions preserve evidence while creating another documented layer to evaluate.
- **C:** Incorrect: digital imaging does not perform textual criticism or dating.
- **D:** Incorrect: search results are leads that require source verification.

Trap 30 - Digital-certainty trap: access and searchability are not authenticity or interpretation.

Q31

Which comparison is correct?

- **A.** Ashokan edicts are private memoirs; the Prayaga inscription is a market account.
- **B.** Land grants are neutral village surveys; donor records include every inhabitant.
- **C.** Ashokan edicts express official communication, the Prayaga prashasti royal eulogy, and land grants recorded legal-fiscal acts.
- **D.** All three genres are equally representative of popular opinion.

Correct answer: C.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: both genre identifications are wrong.
- **B:** Incorrect: legal and donative records remain selective.
- **C:** Correct: the genres differ in purpose and hence historical yield.
- **D:** Incorrect: official and elite records cannot stand for popular opinion without corroboration.

Trap 31 - Inscription-flattening trap: 'epigraphic' is a medium, not one uniform genre.

Q32

A historian finds a textual reference to an early port, imported ceramics in a secure layer, a local inscription naming merchants and a later traveller's description. What is the best conclusion?

- **A.** The traveller proves every earlier detail.
- **B.** The text alone establishes total trade volume.
- **C.** The ceramics automatically identify the ethnicity of merchants.
- **D.** Independent evidence supports connectivity, while chronology, scale, source purpose and residual uncertainty must remain explicit.

Correct answer: D.

Option-specific explanations

- **A:** Incorrect: a later traveller cannot validate every earlier claim.
- **B:** Incorrect: literary reference does not quantify exchange.
- **C:** Incorrect: artefacts do not directly identify merchant ethnicity.
- **D:** Correct: the sources converge on connectivity but retain distinct limits.

Trap 32 - Totalising-convergence trap: triangulation strengthens a specific claim, not every imaginable extension.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED ROUTED PYQS ONLY

Official wording and key status are preserved. A locally unavailable official key is never invented or silently upgraded from analytical elimination.

PYQ 1 - 2018 GS-I Mains Q2

Official question: Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution (within 150 words): Chinese and Arab accounts are indispensable but selective external witnesses. Faxian and Xuanzang reconstruct pilgrimage routes, monasteries, learning centres and regional conditions; their Buddhist purpose magnifies monastic institutions and leaves other social worlds unevenly seen. Sulaiman and al-Masudi illuminate Indian Ocean commerce and the external reputation of Indian polities, although merchant information and hearsay can blur direct observation. Al-Biruni's *Tahqiq-i-Hind* uses Sanskrit learning to discuss sciences, geography, religion and social classification; its north-western setting and elite textual access narrow its reach. Correlation with Nalanda's archaeology, inscriptions, coins, ports and Indian texts converts these observations into firmer history. Travellers thus provide datable comparison and otherwise omitted detail, but remain situated witnesses rather than neutral all-India surveys.

Demand route: assess relative value -> Chinese evidence -> Arab-Persian evidence -> standpoint and transmission limits -> corroborated verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2023 Prelims Q46

Verified question form: Match *Devichandraguptam*, *Hammira-Mahakavya*, *Milinda-panha* and *Nitivakyamrita* with the figures named in the official question; determine how many pairs are correct.

Official-key discipline: The local official 2023 key is unavailable. No official answer option is recorded.

Complete analytical solution: *Devichandraguptam* is associated with Vishakhadatta, not Bilhana. *Hammira-Mahakavya* is associated with Nayachandra Suri. *Milinda-panha* centres on the dialogue between King Milinda and Nagasena and should not be attributed to Nagarjuna. *Nitivakyamrita* is associated with Somadeva Suri. The evidence analysis therefore yields two correct pairings, but this analytical conclusion is not labelled an official key.

PYQ 3 - 2024 Prelims Q55

Verified question form: Test the site-state-description rows for Chandraketugarh, Inamgaon, Mangadu and Salihundam.

Official Set-A key: B - rows 2 and 3 only.

Complete solution: Chandraketugarh is in West Bengal, so the Odisha row is wrong. Inamgaon in Maharashtra is a major Chalcolithic site. Mangadu in Kerala is associated with megalithic evidence. Salihundam in Andhra Pradesh is a Buddhist complex known for stupas and monastic remains, not a rock-cut cave-shrine complex. UPSC's construction swaps one coordinate-state, period or site type-so every cell must be tested independently.

ORIGINAL EXAMINER-READY MAINS PRACTICE

ORIGINAL-10A

10 marks | maximum 150 words

Question: Why is archaeological context as important as the artefact itself? Explain with Indian examples.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: An artefact becomes historical evidence through its layer, findspot, association and formation history. At Inamgaon, houses, courtyard soils, animal bones and plant remains form an assemblage from which routine production and subsistence can be inferred; a stray object could not sustain the same claim. Painted Grey Ware in stratified levels at Hastinapura establishes occupation and a ceramic horizon, but not the historicity of epic characters. Likewise, the Jogalthembi hoard's Nahapana coins counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni support relative sequence, yet the selected deposit cannot map an exact frontier. Looting or undocumented collecting may leave metal, form and iconography intact while destroying depositional chronology and social association. Excavation is therefore controlled recovery of relationships: the object supplies attributes, but context determines which historical inference those attributes can responsibly support.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

ORIGINAL-10B

10 marks | maximum 150 words

Question: Compare inscriptions and coins as chronological sources for early historic India.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: Inscriptions commonly provide explicit anchors, whereas coins often construct relative sequence. Ashokan edicts link public communication to a reign and regnal framework, but surviving proclamations do not represent complete annual administration. The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman, dated in the Shaka era, fixes a ruler and public-work claim, though its panegyric remains selective. Coins recover rulers and issue order through legends, portraits, dies and overstrikes. The Jogalthembi Nahapana coins counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni place the undertype before or alongside the oertype and support political succession; hoard selection and prolonged circulation prevent an exact frontier map. Thus inscriptions are strongest for dated acts and genealogical claims, coins for relative issue sequence and movement. Chronology is firmest when an epigraphic date, a numismatic series and a secure archaeological layer converge.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

ORIGINAL-15A

15 marks | maximum 250 words

Question: Ancient literary sources stand between social norm and social reality. Discuss.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: Ancient texts are neither social censuses nor inventions; their genres place them between descriptions of life and projects to order it. Dharmashastra texts prescribe varna, property, gender and household conduct. Repeated injunctions establish Brahmanical ideals and anxieties, not uniform compliance; female and non-royal donative inscriptions show practices that prescription does not exhaust, although epigraphy also over-represents donors.

Vedic texts preserve ritual, kinship and economic vocabulary through long oral layers. Their categories cannot be mapped mechanically onto Painted Grey Ware settlements: archaeology establishes occupation and technology, not the identity of textual peoples. Pali Vinaya and narrative traditions illuminate monasteries, merchants, towns and money terms. Punch-marked coins and early urban archaeology support monetisation and exchange, while canonical redaction and didactic purpose limit direct reportage.

Sangam poems evoke chiefs, war, occupations and ports in Tamilakam. Tamil-Brahmi, craft debris and imported wares at sites such as Arikamedu and Kodumanal support literacy and maritime connectivity, but bardic convention prevents literal quantification. Epic and Puranic genealogies similarly preserve memory only after recension and inscriptional-numismatic checks. Literature is therefore most valuable when the historian asks layer, author, audience and purpose, and studies the gap between articulated norm, remembered order and material practice.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

ORIGINAL-15B

15 marks | maximum 250 words

Question: Archaeology often provides an anonymous history, yet it can be more inclusive than texts. Examine.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: Archaeology is often anonymous because houses, pottery, seeds, bones and refuse rarely name their makers. That weakness can widen history beyond literate elites by recovering routine production, diet, settlement and inequality. At Inamgaon, houses, soils, faunal remains and shells reconstruct animal keeping and exchange, although the actors and mechanism remain unnamed. Kodumanal's craft debris, beads, spindle whorls and Tamil-Brahmi potsherds reveal production, literacy and connectivity outside court narratives, subject to excavation coverage.

Urban material also records collective practice. Harappan wells, drains, courtyards and standardised weights demonstrate household water management and regulated measurement, but the undeciphered script prevents confident identification of institutions. Sanchi and Bharhut combine monuments with short donor inscriptions that bring women, artisans and lay patrons into view; durable religious giving nevertheless survives better than ordinary housing. Archaeobotany and faunal analysis recover food and labour, while cemetery and sample selection limit representativeness.

Archaeology is therefore not automatically democratic. Preservation favours stone, pottery and metal; survey priorities and museum collecting shape discovery; archaeological cultures can be over-socialised into peoples or languages. Regional survey, household excavation, flotation, osteology and full publication improve inclusion. Archaeology may

not name most ordinary people, but it reconstructs the material conditions in which they lived.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

ORIGINAL-20A

20 marks | maximum 250 words

Question: Ancient Indian history is a multi-source reconstruction rather than a narrative contained in one archive. Critically examine.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: No archive covers the whole ancient past. Archaeology, texts, inscriptions, coins and foreign accounts reveal different scales and carry different silences; reconstruction therefore requires question-specific weighting.

Harappan history rests on cities, craft debris, weights, seals and burials. These establish urban planning and standardised practices, but the undeciphered script blocks an indigenous narrative and cautions against naming the polity. Vedic and epic texts preserve ritual, kinship and memory, while Painted Grey Ware establishes material sequence; overlap does not prove an epic event or linguistic identity.

For early urbanisation, Pali money vocabulary, punch-marked coins and settlement archaeology jointly support monetisation, though use remained uneven. Mauryan reconstruction is firmer because Ashokan edicts, Pataliputra remains and Megasthenes' transmitted fragments converge on kingship and an imperial centre. Yet edicts state policy, archaeology rarely reveals intention, and the classical account survives later quotation.

Regional evidence repeats the method. Nashik-Karle inscriptions and Jogalthembi overstrikes illuminate Deccan patronage and succession without fixing exact borders. Sangam poems, Tamil-Brahmi, craft remains and imported wares support maritime connectivity, not total trade volume. The Prayaga prashasti and Gupta coins reconstruct royal ideology, not universal prosperity.

Critical reconstruction authenticates, dates, matches scale, tests independence and preserves contradiction. It is not a vote among sources: convergence narrows possibilities, while explicit limits prevent evidence from becoming myth or overconfident narrative.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

ORIGINAL-20B

20 marks | maximum 250 words

Question: Scientific techniques have transformed ancient-history research, but they have not eliminated interpretation. Analyse.

MODEL ANSWER BODY: Scientific archaeology converts material remains into testable chronological, biological and environmental evidence, but every result remains sample-bound and context-dependent.

Radiocarbon dating provides calibrated probability ranges for organic material. Contamination, old wood and insecure association mean it dates the sample's death, not automatically a structure or event. Thermoluminescence and OSL estimate last heating or light exposure; depositional disturbance can still weaken the historical link. Archaeobotanical flotation recovers seeds and charcoal, while faunal age profiles illuminate diet or herd management. Recovery strategy and preservation decide whose foodways survive.

Material science can test alloy composition and production technology. A change in coin purity may reflect metal scarcity, increased currency demand or fiscal policy rather than inevitable collapse. Remote sensing and GIS reveal palaeochannels, roads or buried anomalies, but ground verification and dating remain necessary. Stable isotopes can address diet and mobility when baselines are sound; ancient DNA can examine ancestry and relatedness. Neither directly identifies language, caste, religion or polity, and small cemetery samples cannot represent an entire civilisation.

Measurement therefore becomes history only through stratigraphy, association, comparison and an explicit social question. Science narrows possibilities, exposes uncertainty and challenges older chronologies; it does not replace interpretation. Its greatest contribution is disciplined constraint, not a falsely self-interpreting past.

Answer architecture: direct thesis -> named evidence -> inference -> source-specific qualification -> graded verdict.

FINAL PRACTICE CHECKLIST

- Identify the source class before using it.
- State what the named evidence establishes and what it cannot establish.
- Match chronology, geography and scale before claiming corroboration.
- Treat texts as genre-bound and archaeology as interpreted context, not transparent fact.
- Preserve official-key status exactly.